

Neil Kester, PMP, DASSM

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

A results-driven **Technical Manager** with over 20 years of experience leading high-performing teams in complex operational environments. I employ selfless leadership, engineering expertise, and data science methodologies to deliver large-scale technical solutions. Proven track record in driving high-impact programs through **Agile Project Management** and **Systems Thinking** to **improve organizational performance**. Adept at mentoring technical teams, managing enterprise-level projects, and translating analytical insights into strategic decisions. Seeking a Technical Program Manager role to leverage expertise in data-driven problem-solving and cross-functional leadership.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- **Behavioral:** Active Listening, Decision-Making, Resilience, Empathy, Interpersonal Communication.
- **Functional:** Strategic Planning, Systems Analysis, Agile Project Management, Value Delivery, Operations Research, Quantitative Analysis, Data Visualization, and Statistical Analysis.
- **Professional:** Mentorship, Systems Thinking, Strategic Awareness, and Stakeholder Communication.

CERTIFICATIONS

- Disciplined Agile Senior Scrum Master (**DASSM**)
- Project Management Professional (**PMP**)
- Google Cloud Generative AI Leader
- Udacity Introduction to Machine Learning with TensorFlow Nanodegree
- TS/SCI Security Clearance

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- R Programming (Expert)
- MS Excel (Expert)
- MS PowerPoint (Expert)
- MS Word (Expert)

LEADERSHIP & SOFT SKILLS

- Critical Thinking
- Resilience
- Dependability
- Creative Thinking
- Value Focused
- Integrity
- Self-Initiative
- Decision Focused
- Written Communication
- Empathetic Leadership

EDUCATION

Master of Science (MS), Systems Engineering | Johns Hopkins Whiting School of Engineering (2017 – 2021)

Master of Science (MS), Engineering Management | Missouri University of Science and Technology (2009 – 2010)

Bachelor of Science (BS), Civil Engineering | United States Military Academy (USMA) (2002 – 2006)

WORK EXPERIENCE

July 2025 - Now

Department Director - University Department of Operations Sciences; U.S. Army

Direct program strategy and curriculum design for ORSA and senior-leader portfolios, aligning technical analytics with enterprise priorities. Lead a nine-member educator team, overseeing performance management and professional development. Implement agile practices to modernize pedagogy and tools while serving as primary senior leader program instructor. Manage program governance, resource allocation, and performance metrics for senior stakeholders to ensure we continuously deliver education value.

Accomplishments:

- Restored organizational focus and mission clarity by implementing a strategic prioritization framework, leading to a sponsor-endorsed reorganization and a significant increase in operational value delivery.
- Led the delivery of 1,700 hours of graduate-level analytics education in one year, saving the Army hundreds of thousands in tuition costs while accelerating the delivery of mission-critical technical talent.

August 2022 - June 2025

Department Director - Assessments and Analysis; U.S. Army

Direct program strategy and long-term priorities for a large organization's 3–5-year planning horizon. Manage a nine-person team of researchers and analysts, overseeing performance and workload distribution. Lead concurrent analytic projects and cross-functional initiatives using Systems Thinking to architect resource management solutions. Champion Lean and Agile practices to align technology investments with enterprise strategy. Establish governance to track program performance, quality controls, and stakeholder requirements.

Accomplishments:

- Architected a product-centric resourcing framework that optimized annual budget requests by 10% and provided executive leadership with logical traceability from funding to delivered value.
- Established a comprehensive strategic assessment framework for the organization, shifting leadership focus from activity-based metrics to outcome-oriented achievements across a large geographic focus area.

August 2019 - June 2022

Senior Technical Program Manager / Senior Data Scientist; U.S. Army

Define program strategy and priorities for data science and technical portfolios to support enterprise decision-making. Lead cross-functional Agile teams delivering global data capabilities and managing the full project lifecycle from requirements through production and deployment. Architect scalable technical solutions integrating analytics and automation into workflows. Establish governance for data quality and reproducible analytic pipelines while communicating technical status and recommendations to senior leadership.

Accomplishments:

- Architected a high-resilience microservices application using GitOps and Kubernetes, enabling declarative scaling and zero-rework deployments via automated CI/CD pipelines in a highly regulated environment.
- Implemented a secure, automated Agile management framework using Jira and GitLab, providing the Chief Data Officer with real-time visibility into project health through automated dashboards and structured sprint cycles.
- Modernized an R-based analytic application into a resilient, production-grade system by implementing TDD and automated GitLab CI/CD pipelines, eliminating breaking changes and uncovering critical latent bugs.

January 2018 - July 2018

Data Science Team Lead; U.S. Army

Direct technical strategy and data value initiatives in high-ambiguity environments. Lead specialized operations to extract insights from massive datasets while architecting custom applications using Python, R, and PostgreSQL. Oversee the full software development lifecycle, utilizing NLP and API integrations. Manage high-velocity Agile deployments and engage cross-functional stakeholders to align technical capabilities with organizational objectives, driving continuous improvement and governing data management.

Accomplishments:

- Transformed the data science team into a central strategic pillar by delivering proactive, narrative-driven analytics that institutionalized data-informed decision-making across the enterprise.
- Architected an enterprise-scale data fusion system that increased analytical capacity from hundreds to millions of observations, institutionalizing a data-centric culture across the organization.
- Developed an ETL pipeline that reduced data processing time by 99% and increased data coverage from 1% to 85% for mission-critical forward operations.